

HASHKAMA WEEKLY



פרשת דברים

ג' אב תשפ"ו

JULY 17, 2026

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By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Morai veRabbos, we open Sefer Devarim with Moshe Rabbeinu giving his final shmues to Bnei Yisroel, but he does something that every shul Rabbi wishes he could pull off: he gives tochacha without actually getting yelled at by the board. The pasuk says, "Eleh hadevarim asher diber Moshe el kol Yisroel beEver HaYarden beMidbar baAravah mol Suf bein Paran uVein Tofel veLavan vaChatzeros veDi Zahav" (Devarim 1:1). Rashi (Devarim 1:1), quoting the Sifrei, points out that these are not just GPS coordinates for the Waze app; rather, Moshe is listing the places where Bnei Yisroel made mistakes and angered Hashem. Because of kavod for Bnei Yisroel, Moshe Rabbeinu only mentions the names of the places as a remez, instead of explicitly listing their aveiros. Moshe knew better than to send out a subtle mass email. He understood that if you want a Litvish tzibbur to actually listen to your drasha without threatening to cut your parnassah, you cannot point fingers directly. You just vaguely mention "Tofel veLavan" and let the baalei batim squirm in their seats, wondering if you are talking about their talking during chazaras hashatz or the kiddush club. It is the ultimate display of middos. Moshe Rabbeinu teaches us that real ahavas Yisroel means caring enough to give the tochacha, but doing it with such an unbelievable level of eidelkeit that the recipient keeps his dignity intact. But why did Moshe have to tread so carefully with this specific tzibbur? The answer comes just a few pesukim later, where we see exactly what kind of kehillah Moshe was dealing with. He laments, "Eicha esa levadi torachchem uMasaAchem veRivchem" (Devarim 1:12). Rashi (Devarim 1:12) brings down from Chazal that Bnei Yisroel were constant apikorsim who scrutinized Moshe's every move. If Moshe left his tent early, they said he was having shalom bayis issues with Tzipporah. If he left late, they said he was sitting inside scheming how to embezzle the funds from the mishkan. You simply cannot win with these people, no matter what. This perfectly connects back to his method of tochacha. Moshe knew he was dealing with a tzibbur that was inherently defensive, litigious, and ready to argue about the thermostat setting in the midbar. If he had given them direct mussar, they would have formed a breakaway minyan in Chatzeros before Mincha. By using a remez, Moshe bypassed their natural "veRivchem" and forced them to look inward instead of looking for a microphone to complain to the board. He managed the impossible: he led a stubborn generation for forty years, handled their endless complaints without resigning, and still managed to give them a powerful ethical will that built their neshamos for the rest of history. The **practical takeaway** for all of us is how we handle our interactions in the beis midrash and beyond. Most of us are not Moshe Rabbeinu, but we certainly have plenty of people around us who specialize in "torachchem uMasaAchem veRivchem." The next time you feel the need to correct a fellow mispallel about his halacha or his shuckling speed, skip the direct confrontation. Please do not announce his aveiros in front of the whole chevra. Use a little remez, show some kavod, and focus on your own avodah. And if someone happens to leave shul a little early, maybe just assume they are beating the traffic, not embezzling from the pushke. Good Shabbos to you all.

News & Simchos!

This week's regular Kiddush features pastries, Kokosh cake, and a mercifully short shiur. Endure a few minutes of rigorous Torah analysis to officially justify your massive carbohydrate intake.

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:54/8:08 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

מנחה - קבלת שבת 7:00 pm

שקיעה 8:26 pm

עלות השחר (16.1/72) 3:55/4:27 am

נץ החמה 5:39 am

שחרית (14 Sergio) 7:00 am

ס"ז קריאת שמע 8:45/9:21 am

ס"ז תפילה 10:10/10:35 am

חצות היום 1:03 pm

מנחה גדולה (גר"א) 1:39 pm

מנחה (14 Sergio) 1:45 pm

מנחה קטנה (גר"א) 5:21 pm

פלג המנחה (גר"א) 6:53 pm

שקיעה 8:25 pm

צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50) 9:14/9:15 pm

מעריב (52) 9:17 pm

צה"כ (60/72) 9:25/9:37 pm



משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Morai veRabbos, imagine the classic scenario of two yungeleit, Reuven and Shimon, who share a shtender in the back of the beis midrash. Reuven harbors a secret resentment toward Shimon because Shimon always gets shishi on Yom Tov, while Reuven gets stuck with hagbah for the heaviest sefer Torah in the aron on a regular Monday morning. Reuven, sitting and stewing in his makom kavua, becomes absolutely convinced that Shimon is actively lobbying the gabbai against him. Because Reuven feels animosity toward Shimon, he starts interpreting every single action Shimon takes as a calculated, personal attack. If Shimon brings an iced coffee to second seder, Reuven assumes Shimon is flaunting his kollel stipend. If Shimon says a hearty "Good Shabbos" after davening, Reuven is certain it is laced with deep sarcasm. Reuven's resentment boils over one afternoon, and he finally confronts Shimon in the hallway, yelling about the great conspiracy to ruin his reputation in the kehillah. Shimon looks at him with unadulterated confusion, reaches into his kapote, pulls out a beautifully wrapped sefer, and says, "I have no idea what you are talking about; I just spent an afternoon picking out this Chiddushei Rabbeinu Chaim HaLevi as a present for your birthday." Reuven's internal animosity had created a completely fictional reality where his best friend was his mortal enemy.

Nimshal: This dynamic is exactly what Moshe Rabbeinu addresses when he recounts the catastrophic failure of the meraglim in this week's parsha. Moshe reminds Bnei Yisroel of their terrible reaction, saying, "Vatarteku be'oholeichem vatomeru besinas Hashem osanu hotzianu meEretz Mitzrayim" (Devarim 1:27). They sat in their tents and complained, saying, "Because Hashem hates us, He took us out of Mitzrayim to hand us over to the Emori." Rashi (Devarim 1:27) explicitly quotes a famous proverb to explain this absurd psychological projection: "Ma d'ibelabeich al chavrach, chavrach alach." Whatever is in your heart about your friend, you assume is in his heart about you. Hashem loved Bnei Yisroel profoundly, but because they harbored animosity and doubt in their own hearts toward Hashem, they projected that exact hatred onto Him. They convinced themselves that the very Borei Olam who split the Yam Suf and fed them mon every single day was actually out to get them. In our own lives as Litvaks, we are trained to analyze every detail, to break down a complex sugya, and to constantly ask "farvos." But sometimes we mistakenly apply our sharp lomdus to the Ribbono Shel Olam's hashgacha pratis and come up with the wrong maskana entirely. We hit a bump in parnassah, a frustrating delay in shidduchim, or a massive plumbing disaster erev Pesach, and we immediately assume the Eibeshter is punishing us out of strict din. We project our own frustrations onto Shamayim, convincing ourselves that Hakadosh Baruch Hu is acting out of "sinas Hashem." We forget that He is the Ultimate Mashpia, pouring out bracha even when He hands us the spiritual equivalent of hagbah instead of an aliya.

Practical Takeaway: The practical avodah for us this week is to actively stop our internal "vatarteku be'oholeichem" monologues before they spiral out of control. When the air conditioning in the shul inexplicably breaks exactly on the hottest Shabbos morning in late July, do not automatically assume Hashem is specifically targeting your seat in the back row to make you suffer. We have to recognize that Hakadosh Baruch Hu loves us infinitely more than we could ever love ourselves. The next time you face a difficult nisayon, whether it is a massive bill you were not expecting or a chavrusa who keeps showing up twenty minutes late to night seder, instead of projecting your own negativity onto Shamayim, use that Litvish kup to find the ahavah hidden in the situation. Switch your perspective to realize that absolutely everything is a matanah from the Eibeshter, perfectly designed for your tachlis. When we stop projecting our own cynicism onto the Borei Olam, we suddenly realize that we are surrounded by His chesed at every single moment. And perhaps, instead of grumbling at the gabbai about your lack of kibbudim or complaining about the complexities of hashgacha pratis, just be profoundly thankful you did not get stuck wandering a dry midbar for forty years without a working coffee machine. Good Shabbos.

Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:49/8:03 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

שקיעה 8:21 pm

שחרית (14 Sergio) 7:00 am

שקיעה 8:20 pm

מעריב (52) 9:12 pm

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why did Moshe Rabbeinu wait until the congregation was camped on the edge of the Jordan River to deliver the lengthy speeches of Parshas Devarim?

Answer: After forty years of wandering the wilderness without a permanent home, he figured it was finally time to give them a permanent address.

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GOOD SHABBUS!